

Identity Boards: Exploring Use of Mixed Media Expression in Online Queer Spaces

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Abstract

Our project “Identity Boards” on Discord, is an extension tool to promote healthy communication within LGBTQIA+ communities, that aim to reduce microaggressions and foster a more inclusive online environment. “Identity Boards” enable users to visually express their experiences and identities through customized media collections, creating a space for self-expression and understanding. Drawing insights from our co-design workshops, the “Identity Boards” highlights how non-verbal communication, such as sharing movies, songs, and memes, can help users navigate identity, reduce reliance on strict or fixed definitions in defining people’s identities, and promoting conversations within queer spaces. This approach aligns with broader inclusive design goals by address challenges such as “term-policing”, and limited representation in digital environment. In this article, we demonstrate how integrating extensions like “Identity Boards” into existing platforms can create safer, more supportive environments for LGBTQIA+ users, encouraging equality and respect in online spaces.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Participatory design**; *Social networking sites*.

Keywords

User centered design, Online Queer Spaces, LGBTQIA+ Individuals

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1 Introduction

Reducing inequality is important to the global society, as outlined in the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Despite progress in promoting equality, marginalized groups such as the LGBTQIA+ community continue to face unique challenges in online spaces. These include “term-policing”, where members of the LGBTQIA+ community find issue with and attempt to correct how other members are using certain terms they identify by. Additionally, limited representation, and exclusionary designs that hinder self-expression and meaningful participation. Digital platforms often make these problems worse by their strict systems that does not reflect the full spectrum of queer identities, which can make people feel invisible or excluded. Within queer spaces, people interpret and express their identity differently, which could leave people insecure and confused about their identities. If a platform or an online community only allows fixed labels or does not let users share their lived experiences as they grapple with their own identities, it can make even inclusive spaces feel restrictive and unwelcoming.

To address these challenges, our project introduces “Identity Boards”, a tool designed for Discord to promote healthy communication and self-expression within LGBTQIA+ communities. By conducting research and co-design, we understand how users visually express their lived experiences through customizable media collections, Identity Boards provide an alternative to text-based identity definitions that often fail to capture the complexity of queer experiences. This approach aligns with inclusive design principles, to promote healthy discussions and reducing microaggressions in online spaces. Through this paper, we introduce the functionality of the “Identity Boards”, and demonstrate how integrating tools like “Identity Boards” into existing platforms can create safer, more supportive environments for LGBTQIA+ users and contribute to reducing inequality in digital environments.

2 Background and Related Work

Microaggressions towards queer communities can happen in small ways, but they can be deeply harmful. These unnoticed actions in

the form of words, designs, or rules, make LGBTQIA+ individuals feel excluded or judged. For example, as Gunturi et al. [3] discuss in their study of racial microaggressions, phrases that seem innocent can carry hidden biases. Similarly, comments like “You don’t look gay” or “You’re too pretty to be a lesbian” may sound “harmless” but reinforce stereotypes about how LGBTQIA+ people should look or act. These statements ignore the diversity of queer identities and send a message that only certain types of people are acceptable.

Digital platforms amplify these microaggressions by designing systems that do not account for LGBTQIA+ users. Many platforms, such as Facebook, only recently introduced more gender options but still constrain users within predefined categories, which potentially creates stress for individuals whose identity do not align with binary norms [4]. Many platforms only allow users to choose “Male” or “Female” during sign-up, excluding non-binary or gender-fluid individuals. This forces people to pick categories that do not fit their identities, which can make them feel uncomfortable or worse, invalidated [2]. A phenomenon also discussed by Scheuerman et al., describes how online spaces often fail to address the unique needs of transgender users, further marginalizing them. For example, while some platforms provide safe spaces for identity exploration, harmful design choices such as rigid categorization or unsafe algorithms, create an environment where users must navigate harassment and exclusion[7]. Similar to how Ogbonnaya-Ogburu et al. describes the erasure of marginalized voices in other spaces, this lack of options in digital systems sends a message that queer identities are not valued [5].

Microaggressions are even more complex for LGBTQIA+ individuals who are also part of other marginalized groups. People who face discrimination based on race, gender, and sexuality often experience these layers of bias together. For example, a queer person of color might face both racism and homophobia, which compounds the harm they experience [1, 5].

Riggs et al. use the “Button Portraits” project to help LGBTQIA+ individuals connect with queer history through wearable buttons that play stories from the past. This project allows people to reflect on their identities and feel a sense of belonging [6]. Cheon et al., address microaggressions by focusing on tools to increase moderation and support affected members. They propose features like reporting and rating system for offensive comments and visualizations of common microaggressions through world clouds. Additionally, they emphasize the importance of community support through digital space, called “Inclusify”, where users can share experiences and emotional support [1].

However, the proposed solutions have some challenges, such as difficulty engaging people who do not realize their actions are micro-aggressive and the possibility of creating divisions by focusing on specific groups when categorizing incidents. We found that little design or research has been done focusing on non-text based communications on Discord. Through this project, we hope to contribute to ongoing efforts in HCI research and design to help queer individuals feel more included in their online communities.

3 User Research and Design Approach

To find LGBTQIA+ online community members, we reached out to a queer discord community (primarily lesbian/non-men loving

non men focused) with 400 members. We sent out a interest form to field participants for our co-design Workshop and were able to recruit four participants: two asexual participants and two lesbian participants. This workshop took place over Zoom with the participant activities happening in a Miro workspace. We conducted two workshops with two participants each and the sessions were approximately 120 minutes long. For participant privacy, we only mention them by pseudonym and have redacted any personal identifiers added to their co-design workshop materials.



Figure 1: Finished Co-Design Workshop Artifact

The co-design workshop was split into three activities: identity board creation, discord placement, and group discussion. Participants were tasked with selecting one LGBTQIA+ term (ie. Lesbian, Asexual, Bisexual, etc.) and creating a board showcasing their lived experience as that term using media pulled from websites of their choosing. Participants were urged to not use definitions as a way to keep the boards personal and were given a sample board created by the research team. It is important to note that the sample board was simply a collection of media and had no specific ties to any LGBTQIA+ term as to not sway participants in how they chose to showcase their experiences. By the end of the exercise, participants had created something like Figure 1. Participants then were able to choose what section of discord they thought this functionality should exist. Then, participants swapped boards and were able to add comments in the form of sticky notes about the media presented. Finally, participants shared their thought process as they created their board and explained how the media they chose related to their specific experiences.

4 Findings

4.1 Reddit Observations

In order to gain a deeper understanding of the questioning LGBTQIA+ community on a broad scale, we began our digital observations on Reddit. The subreddits we used were r/questioning and r/Questioningteens to see how individuals in this era of self discovery may navigate their journeys. In completion of these digital observations, we found a mix of responses. Note that these responses have been paraphrased to protect Reddit users' personal privacy. In these particular subreddits, users mentioned experiencing feelings of embarrassment (e.g. I am unsure that if I wanted to transition it

would be attributed to a phase, resulting in some personal embarrassment), fear (e.g. I have suggested my queer sexuality, although I feel I may have introduced something I do not align with entirely anymore), and general discomfort because of the need to categorize themselves. Furthermore, many users questioned the necessity to categorize themselves into a term and describe the practice as inescapable. As a result, our research team recognized that LGBTQIA+ individuals felt uncomfortable choosing labels that best fit them.

4.2 Co-Design Workshop

One of our findings from this workshop is that the identity boards gave participants a common ground to start conversation. Our primary activity focused on using media rather than text based definitions that can appear rigid and not encompass the full spectrum of experience underneath.

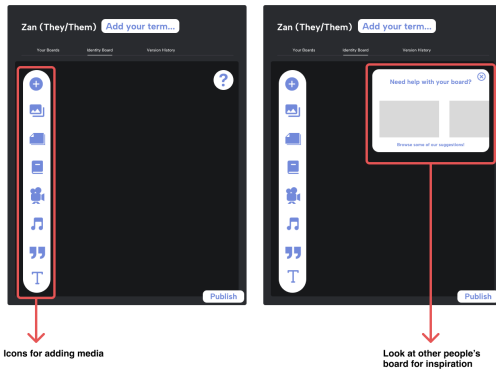


Figure 2: Users can hover to the “add” icon and add any type of media source. Users can also look at other people’s Identity Board for inspiration while making their own.

This use of media allowed for participants to explain their lived experience as a queer person. Another valuable part of this experience was when participants had to explain their board to other group members. This exercise helped facilitate healthy discussion about queer identity and self discovery. Participants having to explain their media choices and their significance helped them to better understand each other and what was most important to them. We also found that the identity boards prompted participants to think about their lived experience in different ways than they had previously. Participants’ choices of media, from memes to movies, helped them reflect on their journey of understanding their queerness and finding their place in LGBTQIA+ online spaces. Participants suggested that this kind of functionality was best received in the discord profile section, as the act of looking at one’s profile to learn more information is a particularly common behavior in LGBTQIA+ online spaces (ie. pronoun preference, relationship status, etc.).

5 Design Ideation

5.1 Overview

We designed Discord Identity Boards to be a new feature on the platform that allows users to create visual collages to express their lived experience with different terminology related to their identity. We chose Discord as a platform because of how often it is used to host online communities for LGBTQIA+ people. Our research and workshops found that when members of the LGBTQIA+ community express how they define the terms they use through visual collages it allows other members to understand their identity beyond the surface level of a gender/sexuality based label. Identity Boards include a board creating tool, context tags for specific media, a board version history, commenting on other’s boards, and timed board sharing.

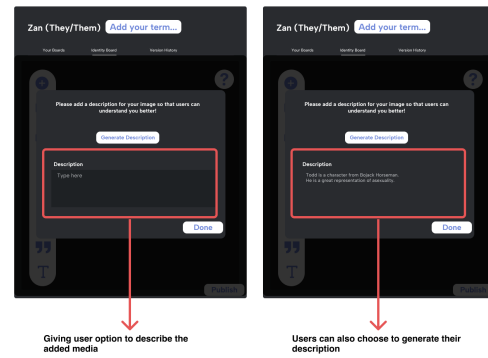


Figure 3: Once users uploaded their content, they can choose to add a description to their content. Users can also use generative AI to write a description for them. The description will appear in the alt-text function once they have published their Identity Board.

5.2 Key Product Features

5.2.1 Identity Board. We designed the identity board as a tool to help users express themselves by creating a collection of media that represents their identity, interests, or inspirations.

Users can add different types of media, like images, videos, text, or links, by hovering over the “add” icon and choosing what they want to include. This makes it easy for people to customize their boards in a way that feels personal and meaningful to them, as shown in Figure 2. At the same time, users can explore other people’s Identity Boards to get ideas or find inspiration. We hope that by looking at how others express themselves, it will encourage new users who might feel unsure about where to start or what to include in their own boards. This feature not only allows users to showcase their individuality but also creates a sense of community by encouraging sharing and connection, also as shown in Figure 3.

5.2.2 Context Tags. Our prototype for adding context-tags did not differ much from our ideation sketches, beyond providing an alternative method of generation akin to how PowerPoint or other tools generate alt-text automatically. We created this feature to be

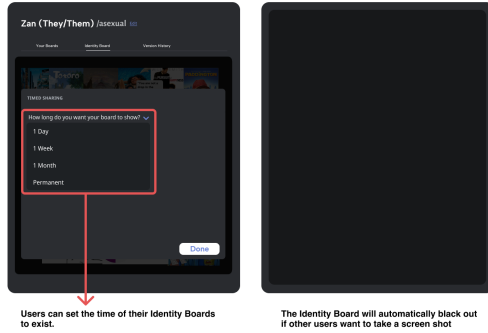


Figure 4: For security and privacy features, users are given the option to choose how long their Identity Board can stay in public. Their Identity Boards will automatically black out if other people want to take a screen shot of it.

optional, as some users discussed how their creative flow could be interrupted by feeling like they had to add context tags and alt-text to every piece of media, as shown in Figure 3.

5.2.3 Privacy in Sharing Methods. Our prototype for temporary sharing focused on allowing users to share their identity boards within specific channels. While we only highlight four options here, we also thought through having custom times for shorter time spans for sharing. Another privacy feature we created after sketching involved screenshots, or the intended lack thereof. Our idea was that any attempts at screenshotting would trigger an auto-blackout of the board, akin to Netflix or other streaming services, as shown in Figure 4.

5.2.4 Viewing and Chatting Friends’ Boards. Our prototype for viewing boards are very similar to our ideation sketches, with the primary difference being an expansion and exploration of how users can modify what boards are visible to others.

We also received feedback during evaluation that it was not entirely clear that users could have multiple boards for different terms, which we attempted to make clear with the personal board view, as shown in Figure 5.

Another feature of the identity board is to encourage conversations within the LGBTQIA+ communities. To achieve this, we included a feature where viewers can click on shared content, such as a show, movie, meme, or image, and start a conversation with the board creator about the story or meaning behind it, as shown in Figure 6.

5.2.5 Board Version History. The largest addition we made for our prototype is the inclusion of a version history for boards. Workshop participants highlighted that their terminology and experiences change over time. We wanted to represent this change through our prototype. Our core idea involved a private version history for terms and the boards attached to them. This would only be accessible to the user and ideally allow them to reflect on the journey they’ve had with their identity. They do not have to make a new board unless they want to, but the option allows them to explore how

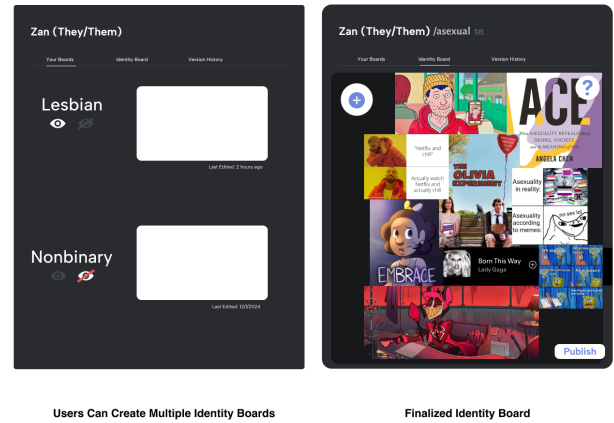


Figure 5: The “Your Boards” function shows how terms and board can change over time, allows users to reflect evolving identities and labels. This “make public” and “make private” feature lets users view their changes and reflect on their personal journey, instead of just editing and replacing terms.

different terms have fit them or changed over time, as shown in Figure 7.

5.3 Evaluation

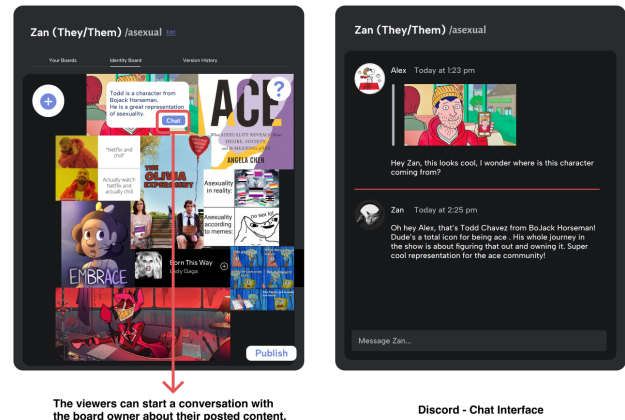


Figure 6: After viewers use the Alt-Text function, they could start a conversation with the board owner if they are curious about their posted content. This could prompt conversation within the LGBTQIA+ community to respect understand each identities.

To evaluate the effectiveness of our Discord functionality we reconnected with three of the participants of our co-design workshop to run through a series of usability tests focused creating and sharing identity boards. Identity boards center around personal



Figure 7: The Version History function allows users to reflect on how their identities and terminology evolve over time. The private history function allows users to track changes to their Identity Boards, which offers them a space for personal reflection.

communication and identity, so our testing focused on how evaluators viewed the usefulness of the tool rather than the specific collaging features implemented. Additionally, we wanted to gauge how intuitive the tool would feel to use within Discord's existing infrastructure, as we wanted to ensure that the functionality would enhance conversations and flow smoothly within pre-existing habits on the platform. Our evaluators found at the board creation process and tools available felt accessible and integrated well into Discord's existing functionality, noting that creating new boards felt like a similar process to online collaging. The emphasis on using Discord's existing command ("/command") feature within different chats was noted to blend into Discord infrastructure. The emphasis on privacy concerns in the form of blocked screenshots and timed board sharing was also received well and mitigated some of the initial concern from the co-design workshop regarding misuse or potential harm in sharing boards without consent. Evaluators also felt that the board version history would reflect the shifting identities of members of the LGBTQIA+ community and be a valuable

resource for reflecting on one's personal journey in relation to a specific term or identity.

Some of the finer details of the functionality were met with some confusion or suggestions. This included refining the user interface to make it more obvious that users can create multiple boards for different terms, to add a higher level of flexibility for time sharing and privacy settings, and to ensure that context tags and explanations on boards were accessible in multiple ways beyond a hover feature.

6 Conclusion

By focusing on reduced inequality, our study facilitated better discussions in LGBTQIA+ online spaces. Our project utilized co-design methods with queer community members to create identity boards that allow for more fluid expression of identity with LGBTQIA+ spaces on Discord. The identity board, focusing more on media than text based definitions, allowed participants to reflect on what specific LGBTQIA+ terminology meant for them. This shift in focus allowed for more nuance in conversations surrounding identity and lived experience in online queer spaces. Our design project also explores and reflects upon some of the struggles of communicating and finding one's place within online queer spaces. In future work, we'd like to expand use of "Identity Boards" to other marginalized communities and juxtapose these experiences against our existing body of work to better understand how mixed media can help online community members grapple with identity, both inside and outside of LGBTQIA+ spaces.

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